Riccardo Di Cato

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Placement Director: Prashant Bharadwaj prbharadwaj@ucsd.edu
Placement Coordinator: Andrew Flores econ-jobmarket@ucsd.edu

Education

University of California San Diego 2021–present
Ph.D. in Economics (expected 2027)
Research areas: Development Economics, Political Economy, and Economic History
Advisors: Sara Lowes and Samuel Bazzi (co-chairs); Paul Niehaus, Gaurav Khanna, and Craig McIntosh

University of Bologna 2018
M.Sc. in Economics, LMEC (*summa cum laude*)

University of Pavia 2016
B.A. in Economics

References

Sara Lowes (Co-chair)
Associate Professor of Economics
Department of Economics, UC San Diego
slowes@ucsd.edu

Samuel Bazzi (Co-chair)
Professor of Economics
School of Global Policy and Strategy, UC San Diego
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Paul Niehaus
Professor of Economics
Department of Economics, UC San Diego
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Gaurav Khanna
Associate Professor of Economics
School of Global Policy and Strategy, UC San Diego
gakhanna@ucsd.edu

Job Market Paper

Seeds of Market-Based Capitalism: Missionaries, Banks, and China's Modernization *with Jiachen Li*

How do modern financial institutions take root? We study this question in the context of China, which transitioned from traditional to modern banking following its opening to foreign powers in the nineteenth century. We explore the role of Christian missionaries in shaping the adoption of modern banks. Missionaries were among the first foreigners to reach China's interior and played an important role in educating future bankers and translating the Western knowledge needed to operate these new institutions. Before the Communist takeover in 1949, we use a staggered difference-in-differences design to show that missionary arrival increased the number of modern banks by 31% and, with a delay, the number of enterprises by 27%. We then estimate the long-run effects of mission exposure after 1949 using variation induced by the timing of railway construction relative to national missionary inflows. The effect of missionary activity on banking disappeared under Maoist central planning but re-emerged as markets reopened after 1978. Evidence on surviving bankers and returning elites suggests that historical human capital became valuable again as China reopened to markets and reformed its financial system in 1984. Beyond banking, locations with greater historical mission exposure have higher GDP, more enterprises, and greater foreign investment. These findings suggest that missionaries planted the seeds of market-based capitalism, which lay dormant before re-emerging to shape China's modern development.

Working Papers

Restricting Online Pornography and Violence Against Women: Evidence from the United States and India *with Santiago Cantillo-Cleves*

Work in Progress

Same Faith, Different Politics: Religious Broadcasting and Voting in Italy and Spain *with Mattia Albertini*

Increasing Female Employment in the Automotive Sector in India *with Garima Sharma, Anant Nyshadham, and Achyuta Adhvaryu*

Religious Broadcasting and Belief Formation in Tanzania *with Mattia Albertini*

Employment

National Bureau of Economic Research 2022
Research Assistant (Prof. Samuel Bazzi)

Bocconi University 2019–2021
Research Associate (Prof. Nicola Limodio and Prof. Filippo De Marco)

Harvard University 2018–2019
Field Research Associate in DR Congo (Profs. N. Nunn, J. A. Robinson, S. Lowes, and J. Weigel)

Founder and Manager, Hospitality Business 2015–2020
Established and operated three tourist residences in Italy

Presentations

NBER Religion (discussant)	Forthcoming
NEUDC, Cornell University	Forthcoming
UC Irvine Seminar (invited)	Forthcoming
Economic History Mini-Conference, UCLA	2026
WEFIDEV Webinar Series in Finance and Development	2026
ASREC Europe Conference, Venice	2026
Economic History Association Annual Meeting, St. Louis	2026
SIOE Conference, INSEAD	2026
HHDI–NIDE Workshop, Belfast	2026
IRES Workshop, Chapman University	2026
ASREC Conference, Chapman University	2026
ASREC Conference, George Mason University	2025
SOCAE Conference, UCLA	2025
DevPEC Conference, UC Berkeley	2025
University of Bologna WiP Seminar	2025
Migration and Development Conference, Bologna	2024
Boston University Center for the Study of Asia	2024

Teaching Experience

University of California San Diego 2021–present

Graduate: Financial Accounting; Quantitative Methods II; Quantitative Methods III

Undergraduate: Microeconomics (principles and intermediate); Financial Accounting; The Indian Economy

Bocconi University 2020

Undergraduate: Financial Markets and Institutions; Public Finance

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

Cindy Vojtech Summer Research Prize in Economics, UC San Diego ($1,667) 2026

IHS Research & Travel Grant ($2,500) 2026

Summer Research Grant, UC San Diego ($2,720) 2024–2025

Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics ($6,885) 2023

21st Century India Center Travel Grant, UC San Diego ($8,500) 2023

TRELS Grant, UC San Diego ($1,000) 2022

Overseas Scholarship, Université de Montréal 2018

Erasmus Scholarship, Université Pierre Mendès France 2015

Referee Service

Journal of Development Economics; Economic Development and Cultural Change, Mission Studies

Mentoring and Community Involvement

Co-founder, Undergraduate–Graduate Economic Research Lab, UC San Diego

Co-founder and co-host, Backstory Podcast at UC San Diego

Organizer and director, church summer camp, Omegna, Italy; college-student mentor

Co-founder, "Yes, I Care" community-meeting project; volunteer with Suñu Diwaan, Senegal

Additional Information

Programming	Stata, R, ArcGIS, LaTeX, GeoODK (advanced); Python (intermediate); Matlab (basic)
Languages	*Native:* Italian. *Fluent:* English, French. *Intermediate:* Spanish.
Citizenship	Italian citizen; U.S. permanent resident; married to a Spanish-American citizen